North Coast Gnarwhals

New Parent & Rider Guide

Welcome to the **North Coast Gnarwhals** We're stoked to have you join our pod. Whether your student-athlete is new to riding or already shredding trails, this guide will help you understand what we do, what to expect, and how to get rolling.

🌄 About the Gnarwhals & NICA

The **National Interscholastic Cycling Association (NICA)** was founded in 2009 to bring mountain biking to student-athletes across the U.S. It's about more than just racing, it's about building confidence, resilience, community, and a lifelong love of the outdoors.

The **North Coast Gnarwhals** are proud to be the Cleveland area's only NICA team, participating in the **Ohio Interscholastic Cycling League**. We practice primarily at the **Medina mountain bike trail system** and welcome student-athletes in **grades 5–12** from all backgrounds and skill levels.

✅ **No tryouts**
✅ **No cuts**
✅ **No bench** — everyone rides!

🧭 What to Expect

🗓️ Practice Schedule

- **Days:** Every **Monday & Thursday**
- **Time:** 6:00 PM – 7:30 PM
- **First Practice:** Typically the 1st Monday in June
- **Last Practice:** Typically the 1st Thursday in October
- **Monday Location:** Medina Trails (Huffman Trailhead)
- **Thursday Location:** Rotates—Royalview, Bedford, and others (TBD)

Practice Commitment? Totally flexible. Show up when you can. The more, the merrier!

🏁 Race Season

- **Events:** Adventure events begin in June, races start in August
- **Total Races:** Up to 5 events
- **Racing is Optional!** Join as many or as few as you like.

Race schedule and details: https://ohiomtb.org/race-season

🚵 Equipment & Gear

🚲 Do I need to buy a bike?

Nope! The Gnarwhals have bikes available to **loan out** for the season. Just let us know your needs and we'll set you up.

🛠️ Required Gear

- **Helmet** (we can provide one if needed)
- **Water bottle** or hydration pack

👍 Optional (but helpful)

- MTB gloves
- Padded bike shorts
- Sunglasses or clear lenses
- Mini pump and spare tube
- Trail snacks
- Sunscreen & bug spray

Spin Bike Shop offers discounts for NICA riders. Ask us for details!

💰 Costs

Fee Type	Description	Cost
NICA Program Fee	League-wide rider registration	$155
Race Package	Includes all 5 races	$200
Team Fee	Helps cover team gear, tools, snacks	$40
Try-It Program	For first-timers: 1 race, can upgrade later	$60
Sibling Discount	15% off for families with more than one rider	✅

Scholarships and financial aid are available. Don't hesitate to ask, we want everyone who wants to ride to be able to!

👭 Parent Involvement

You don't have to be a biker to support the team! We love our parent volunteers.

- 📣 **Ride Leaders:** Want to ride with us? We'll help you get certified!
- 🔧 **Support Crew:** Help with bike maintenance, gear setup, and race day pit support
- 🍎 **Snacks & Logistics:** Help coordinate rides, snacks, and team campouts
- 📸 **Media Team:** Take photos and help us share the stoke!

❓ Frequently Asked Questions (FAQ)

Do I need to buy a bike?
No! We have team bikes available to loan. Just let us know during registration.

Does my kid have to race?
Not at all. Racing is totally optional—riders can join for the practices and community alone.

My child is new to mountain biking—is that okay?
Absolutely. Most riders start with limited or no experience. We focus on safety, skills, and fun.

What if we have a busy schedule?
No problem. Practices are flexible. Come when you can!

Is there financial aid?
Yes! There are scholarships for registration, gear, and races. Email us for info.

📬 Stay in Touch

- **TeamSnap: Communication app** – you will get a link once reistered
- **Email us:** northcoastgnarwhals@gmail.com
- **Learn More:** https://ohiomtb.org/ride/
- **Follow Us:** facebook.com/northcoastgnarwhals

🙌 Welcome to the Pod!

Being a Gnarwhal means more than riding trails. It's about building grit, confidence, friendships, and memories. Thank you for being part of our team—we can't wait to ride with you!

Let's roll!

Race Weekend Tips & Tricks for New Parents

Your guide to surviving (and enjoying) your first NICA race weekend!

🏕️ Before You Go

✅ Check the Race Info:
Details (parking, camping, course map) are always posted here:
👉 https://ohiomtb.org/race-season/

✅ Pack Early:

- Bike + helmet + shoes
- Team jersey & race plate
- Water bottles/hydration pack
- Extra clothes/layers (weather changes fast!)
- Camping gear (if staying overnight)
- Tools: pump, spare tube, chain lube
- Snacks, meals, cooler (some venues have food trucks)
- Camp chair, sunscreen, bug spray

✅ Bike Check:
Have your rider clean/lube their chain, check tires, brakes, and shifting by Thursday before race weekend. We'll help at practice if needed!

📍 Arrival Tips

- **Arrive early**—parking can be far from the team pit zone.
- Find our **Gnarwhals tent or banner** in the team area.
- Check in with a coach and get your rider's race plate installed if not already.

🕘 Race Day Flow

1. **Get Settled:** Set up camp chairs and coolers near the Gnarwhals pit area.

   There is limited space available for parents, some races there may be other options to set up for the day

2. **Pre-Ride:** Most riders do a lap of the course the day before or morning of.
3. **Warm-Up & Line-Up:** Coaches help riders warm up and get to staging.
4. **Race Time!** Cheer loud! (Cowbells optional, but encouraged.)
5. **Post-Race:** High-fives, snacks, cool down. Riders return plates and debrief with coaches.
6. **Hang Out:** Many families stay to cheer on teammates, relax, or explore.

🧺 Parent Pro Tips

- Bring a towel or baby wipes — dirt happens!
- Label water bottles & gear (trust us).
- Download the **TeamSnap** app to get updates on start times & locations.
- Races run on *"NICA Time"*—flexibility and patience are key.
- Be a positive fan! NICA is about effort, not placement.

🤝 Stay Connected

- Ask other parents for help or tips—we've all been there!
- Volunteer for snacks, setup, or support—more hands = less stress.
- Camp with the team for max fun (and s'mores).

💙 Remember:

This is about growth, not gold medals. Win or flat tire, every Gnarwhal gets a high five and a granola bar!

See you at the races!

Sample Event Weekend Schedule

Saturday

9:00 AM Volunteer Shifts Begin (check-in at the Volunteer Tent)

11:30 AM Pit Zone Access Open

12:00 PM Registration Opens

12:30 PM *Coaches Pre-Ride (meet at the Finish Line Arch) *_Everyone on course must have a race plate_

1:00 PM NICA GRiT Meet & Greet (meet at the NICA GRiT tent)

1:30 PM *NICA GRiT Pre-Ride (meet at the NICA GRiT tent)

2:30 PM *Pre-Ride Open to All Teams/ Riders *_Everyone on course must have a race plate_

4:00 PM NICA GRiT Activities (meet at the NICA GRiT tent)

5:00 PM Pre-Ride Closed - (No riders allowed on course after pre-ride is closed)

5:00 PM Registration Closes

5:30 PM Friends and Family Ride (open to the public)

Sunday

7:00 AM Registration Opens

7:30 AM *Pre-Ride Open to All Teams/ Riders *_Everyone on course must have a race plate_

8:00 AM Volunteer Shifts Begin (check-in at the Volunteer Tent)

8:30 AM Pre-Ride Closed

8:30 AM Head Coaches Meeting (Meet at the Finish Line Arch)
Plan to be at the staging area 15-20 minutes prior to each athlete's grade start time.

9:00 AM Staging - Wave 1 (Middle School Boys and Middle School Open)

9:15 AM Racing Begins (MS Boys and Open)

10:15 AM Staging - Wave 2 (Middle and High School Girls)

10:30 AM Racing Begins (MS and HS Girls)

11:30 AM Registration Closes

11:50 PM Staging - Wave 3 (High School Boys and High School Open)

12:05 PM Racing Begins (HS Boys and Open)

1:15 PM Racing Concludes

1:20 PM Pit Zone and Infield Breakdown Begins

3:00 PM Awards Ceremony (** may be earlier depending on finish and tear down times)**